

Relay API Quickstart

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Relay accepts events over HTTPS and delivers them to endpoints that you register. There are exactly two things to configure: a source, which is where events enter the system, and one or more endpoints, which is where they leave it. Everything else has a default that is correct for the majority of integrations, and the most common integration mistake is configuring things that did not need configuring. A working integration is typically forty lines of code on the publishing side and thirty on the receiving side.

Authentication

Authentication uses an API key sent in the X-Nordvane-Key header. Keys are scoped to a single environment and a single region; there are no global keys and no plans to introduce them. A key can be rotated without downtime by creating a second key, migrating traffic to it, and then revoking the first, and both keys remain valid simultaneously for as long as the customer needs. Keys are displayed once at creation and are not retrievable afterwards, because they are stored hashed. A lost key must be replaced rather than recovered, and support cannot recover one either.

Publishing an event

Publishing is a POST to `/v1/events` with a JSON body containing a type, a payload, and optionally an `idempotency_key`. Where an `idempotency_key` is supplied and has been seen within the preceding 24 hours, the request returns 200 and no duplicate event is created, which makes it safe to retry a publish that timed out without knowing whether it succeeded. The idempotency window is fixed at 24 hours and is not configurable per plan.

Field	Type	Required	Notes
type	string	Yes	Dot-separated, e.g. order.created. Max 128 characters.
payload	object	Yes	Arbitrary JSON. Counted toward the payload size limit.
idempotency_key	string	No	Deduplicated within a 24 hour window.
metadata	object	No	Not delivered to endpoints. Visible in Signal.

Table 1. Request body fields for POST `/v1/events`.

Limits and error responses

Status	Meaning	What to do
200	Accepted, or duplicate suppressed by idempotency key	Nothing
400	Malformed body or unknown field	Fix the request; do not retry unchanged
401	Missing or invalid API key	Check the key and its region scope
413	Payload exceeds 256 KB	Send a reference rather than the payload itself
429	Publish rate limit exceeded	Back off for the duration in the Retry-After header
503	Region temporarily unavailable	Retry with exponential backoff

Table 2. Publish API responses. The maximum accepted payload size is 256 kilobytes on every plan.

Publish rate limits are 500 requests per second on Starter and Growth and 5,000 requests per second on Scale. Exceeding the limit returns 429 together with a Retry-After header, and clients are expected to honour it. These limits apply to inbound publishing only; they are entirely separate from delivery throughput to endpoints, and separate again from the automatic tenant rate limiting described in the retry semantics document, which is a protective mechanism rather than a plan limit. Confusing these three is the most common source of misunderstanding in support tickets about rate limits.

Receiving deliveries

Outbound deliveries carry two headers that your receiver should verify on every request. X-Nordvane-Signature contains an HMAC-SHA256 signature of the raw request body computed with the signing secret for that endpoint. X-Nordvane-Timestamp contains the Unix timestamp at signing time. The signature must be computed over the raw bytes of the body before any JSON parsing, since re-serialising the parsed body will produce a different byte sequence and a signature that never matches; this is the single most common integration failure and accounts for the largest ticket category in support.

Header	Contents	Verification
X-Nordvane-Signature	HMAC-SHA256 of the raw body, hex encoded	Compare using a constant-time comparison
X-Nordvane-Timestamp	Unix timestamp at signing time	Reject if more than 5 minutes from your own clock
X-Nordvane-Event-Id	Unique event identifier	Use for your own deduplication
X-Nordvane-Attempt	Attempt number, 1 for the first delivery	Informational

Table 3. Headers present on every outbound delivery.

Reject any delivery whose timestamp is more than five minutes away from your own clock. Without that check, a captured request can be replayed against your endpoint indefinitely, since the signature itself remains valid forever. The five minute tolerance is a recommendation rather than something Relay enforces, and a receiver with reliable clock synchronisation may safely narrow it.

Your endpoint should return any 2xx status to acknowledge a delivery. Anything else is treated as a failure and enters the retry path described in the retry semantics document. Relay waits 10 seconds for a response before treating an attempt as failed, and a timeout is a failure like any other. Receivers should acknowledge first and process afterwards: endpoints that perform work before responding are the second most common source of support tickets, and the symptom reported is almost always described as Relay being slow rather than as the receiver being slow.